

Q I feel so sick that I can only stomach dry crackers. Is my baby getting everything he needs?

If you are suffering from morning sickness and finding it hard to keep anything down, try changing what you eat and when. Your baby won't suffer.

Your hormones slow your digestive system during pregnancy so that your body can take the maximum nutrients from whatever food you eat. Furthermore, your body prioritizes your baby, drawing reserves of major

nutrients such as calcium and protein from your own body if it needs to. As long as you eat a little, your baby should be fine. If you're worried or vomiting frequently, however, talk to your doctor.

EATING DURING THE DAY

If you are suffering from nausea and vomiting, try these suggestions to help you change the repertoire of what you eat or drink and when.

» **Eat little and often:** Try eating six small meals a day (right) rather than attempt three meals and two snacks.

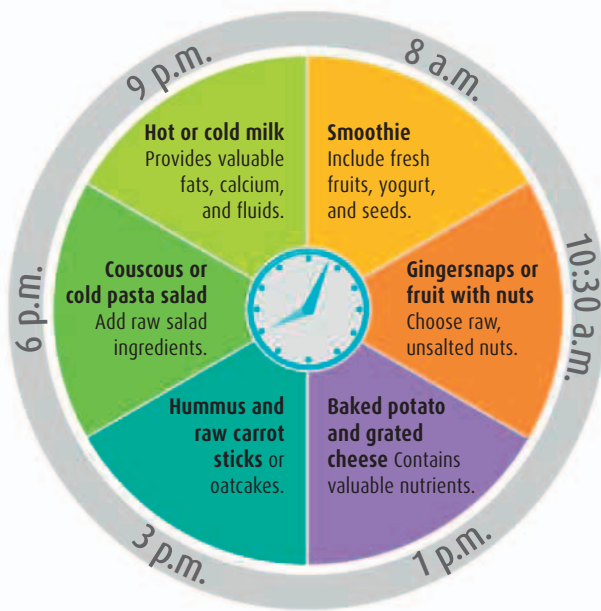
» **Make your food starch rich:** In addition to being bland, which is all you might be able to face, potatoes, rice, pasta, and couscous contain good quantities of nutrients (B-vitamins, iron, protein, and fiber among them).

» **Eat raw foods:** Your queasy response to food often has to do with the smell of it rather than the taste. Raw (or cold) foods tend to have less of an aroma, which might make them more palatable for you.

» **Nibble on snacks:** Unroasted skinned almonds, which are nutrient-dense but plain to taste, are ideal.

» **Sip water:** Try adding a slice of lemon or two, or try hot water with a few mint leaves (which contain potassium, iron, and folate, among other nutrients). Drinking ginger tea can help to suppress nausea.

Sip water infused with a slice of lemon (which provides antioxidants and vitamin C).



Six small meals Break your food intake down into more palatable, manageable minimeals such as these to help you consume enough nutrients each day.



Q I love chocolate and I can't resist eating it. Does this mean my baby will have a sweet tooth?

If you like chocolate, your baby may have a preference for the smell and taste of chocolate.

However, as long as your diet is healthy, with chocolate as a small and occasional indulgence (choose organic, dark varieties that are high in flavanols), your overall influence is a good one. A French study at the European Centre for Taste Science in 2012 concluded that what a mother eats, particularly during the final stages of her pregnancy, can significantly influence a newborn baby's preference for certain foods. It's thought that the flavors of foods pass through the amniotic fluid and into the baby's newly forming olfactory nerves so that when the baby is born, he will turn toward the smell of food that is familiar (and away from food that isn't). Perhaps the most important thing to remember is that any foods you consume that are high in saturated fat and sugar are low in nutritional value. Studies show that a pregnancy diet that is high in sugar and saturated fat can lead to higher birth weight babies and have a longlasting effect on your baby's own dietary choices.

Q Does the fact that I'm skinny and petite mean that I will have a low birth weight baby?

No, not necessarily. The evidence shows that as long as you eat healthily, you will have a full-term baby who is just perfect for his genes. Low birth weight is a medical term meaning that your baby weighs less than 5½lb (2.5kg) when he is born. In a healthy pregnancy without complications, there are two main influences on a baby's birth weight. The first is what you eat while your unborn baby is growing (and, in fact, what you ate before you got pregnant because your previous weight is a factor). A study conducted in Oxford, UK, in 2014 compared the birth weights of 60,000 babies from across the world and concluded that nutrition, even more than the mother's size or her ethnicity, impacted the size of her baby at birth. The second is due to genetics. If you're petite and were yourself a small baby, it's possible (and normal) that your baby will inherit your petite size. Of course,